

Standard Project Lifecycle Framework

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1 Executive Overview

The Standard Project Lifecycle (SPL), branded externally as Meridian Accelerate(TM), is the firm's universal delivery framework, applicable across all Advisory and Consulting engagements regardless of industry, technology stack, or engagement size. Developed over two decades of transformation experience and refined through more than 1,200 completed engagements, the SPL provides a structured yet adaptable approach to delivering measurable client outcomes. Every Meridian project team is required to follow this lifecycle unless a formal exception has been approved by the Practice Lead and the Quality Assurance Director.

The SPL consists of five sequential phases, each with defined entry criteria, key activities, deliverables, governance checkpoints, and exit criteria. While the phases are sequential, iterative loops within individual phases are encouraged, particularly during the Design and Build phases where emerging requirements and stakeholder feedback demand flexibility. The framework is complemented by cross-cutting disciplines including risk management, quality assurance, change management, and benefits realization that operate continuously throughout all five phases.

2 Phase 1: Discover (Weeks 1-6)

The Discover phase establishes a comprehensive understanding of the client's current state, strategic objectives, pain points, and constraints. This phase is foundational; inadequate discovery is the single most common root cause of project overruns and scope disputes across the professional services industry. Meridian mandates a minimum of three weeks for Discover on any engagement exceeding \$500K in total contract value.

2.1 Current-State Assessment

The engagement team conducts a structured current-state assessment that encompasses business processes, technology landscape, organizational structure, data architecture, and regulatory environment. The assessment uses Meridian's proprietary Maturity Model, which evaluates capabilities across five dimensions: process maturity, technology enablement, data governance, talent readiness, and innovation capacity. Each dimension is scored on a 1-5 scale with detailed rubrics.

2.2 Stakeholder Interviews and Workshops

A minimum of 15-25 stakeholder interviews are conducted across executive leadership, middle management, and operational staff. Interviews follow Meridian's Semi-Structured Interview Protocol (SSIP), which balances consistency with the flexibility to probe emerging themes. Workshops are facilitated using the MURAL digital whiteboarding platform for remote participants and physical war-room sessions for co-located teams.

- Executive sponsor alignment sessions (2-3 sessions, 90 minutes each)
- Process owner deep-dives (5-8 sessions covering end-to-end value streams)
- Technology architecture review with client IT leadership
- End-user focus groups to validate pain points and workarounds
- Regulatory and compliance landscape briefing with legal/risk teams

2.3 Pain Point and Opportunity Identification

All pain points, inefficiencies, and opportunities are cataloged in the Meridian Issue & Opportunity Register (IOR). Each entry is scored on a two-dimensional matrix: business impact (revenue, cost, risk, customer experience) and

addressability (technical feasibility, organizational readiness, budget alignment). This prioritized register directly feeds into the Design phase's requirements backlog.

2.4 Discover Phase Deliverables

- Current-State Assessment Report with maturity scores
- Stakeholder Interview Summary and Themes Analysis
- Issue & Opportunity Register (prioritized)
- Preliminary Scope and Boundary Document
- Discover Phase Findings Presentation to Steering Committee
- Updated Risk Register with initial risk ratings

Governance Checkpoint: Discover Gate Review with project Steering Committee. Go/No-Go decision based on completeness of current-state understanding and alignment on project scope boundaries.

3 Phase 2: Design (Weeks 4-12)

The Design phase translates discovery findings into a concrete future-state vision, solution architecture, and detailed requirements. This phase typically overlaps with the final weeks of Discover as early design hypotheses emerge from stakeholder workshops. The Design phase produces the blueprints that govern all subsequent Build and Test activities.

3.1 Future-State Architecture

The future-state architecture encompasses business process models (using BPMN 2.0 notation), technology architecture (logical and physical views following TOGAF ADM), data architecture (conceptual and logical data models), and integration architecture (API specifications, middleware design, event streaming topology). Each architecture artifact undergoes peer review by Meridian's Architecture Review Board (ARB) before client presentation.

3.2 Requirements Specification

Requirements are documented using a tiered approach: business requirements (BRDs) capture strategic outcomes, functional requirements (FRDs) detail system behaviors and user stories, and non-functional requirements (NFRs) address performance, scalability, security, and accessibility standards. Meridian utilizes a RICE scoring model (Reach, Impact, Confidence, Effort) to prioritize the requirements backlog and inform release planning.

3.3 Solution Blueprint

The Solution Blueprint is the single authoritative design document that integrates all architecture views, requirements, assumptions, constraints, and design decisions. It serves as the contract between the project team and the Steering Committee regarding what will be built. Any material deviation from the approved Solution Blueprint requires a formal Change Request.

3.4 Design Phase Deliverables

- Future-State Business Process Models (BPMN 2.0)
- Solution Architecture Document (TOGAF-aligned)
- Functional and Non-Functional Requirements Specification
- Solution Blueprint (integrated design document)
- Data Migration Strategy and Mapping Document

- Integration Design Specification
- Updated Project Plan with Build phase work breakdown structure

Governance Checkpoint: Design Gate Review. The Steering Committee approves the Solution Blueprint, confirming that the proposed design addresses all prioritized requirements within budget and timeline constraints. Formal sign-off required before Build commences.

4 Phase 3: Build (Weeks 10-28)

The Build phase is where the approved design is translated into configured, developed, and integrated solution components. Meridian employs an iterative build approach with two-week sprints, regardless of whether the overall project follows Agile or Waterfall methodology. Each sprint concludes with a demonstrable increment reviewed by the Product Owner and key stakeholders.

4.1 Configuration and Development

Solution components are built following Meridian's Secure Development Lifecycle (SDL), which embeds security reviews, code quality gates, and automated testing at every stage. All configuration changes are version-controlled, and all custom code undergoes mandatory peer review before merge. The team maintains a Definition of Done (DoD) checklist that includes unit test coverage (minimum 80%), code review approval, security scan pass, and documentation updates.

4.2 Data Migration

Data migration follows Meridian's four-stage ETL methodology: Extract (source system data pulls with completeness validation), Transform (cleansing, deduplication, format normalization, business rule application), Load (target system population with referential integrity checks), and Verify (automated reconciliation reports comparing source and target record counts, checksums, and sample audits). A minimum of three mock migrations are conducted before production cutover.

4.3 Build Phase Deliverables

- Configured and developed solution components (sprint increments)
- Unit test results and code coverage reports
- Data migration scripts and reconciliation reports
- Integration test results for component interfaces
- Technical documentation and operations runbooks
- Sprint review recordings and demo artifacts
- Updated risk and issue registers

Governance Checkpoint: Build Completion Gate. Confirmation that all solution components meet the Definition of Done, data migration dry runs are successful, and the solution is ready for formal testing. Entry criteria for Test phase must be satisfied.

5 Phase 4: Test (Weeks 24-34)

The Test phase validates that the solution meets all functional requirements, non-functional standards, and user expectations. Meridian's testing approach is risk-based: test cases are prioritized by the criticality of the underlying

business process and the complexity of the technical implementation. Testing overlaps with the final Build sprints as completed components enter the test pipeline.

5.1 System Integration Testing (SIT)

SIT validates end-to-end business process flows across all integrated system components. Test scenarios are derived from the BPMN process models created during Design and cover both happy-path and exception flows. SIT is executed by the Meridian test team using structured test scripts in Azure DevOps Test Plans or Jira Xray, depending on the client's tooling standards.

5.2 User Acceptance Testing (UAT)

UAT is led by client business users with Meridian facilitation. Test scenarios are written in business language (not technical language) and map directly to the business requirements documented in the BRD. Meridian provides UAT coordinators, defect triage facilitators, and daily status reporting. UAT sign-off by the business process owners is a mandatory prerequisite for deployment.

5.3 Performance and Regression Testing

Performance testing validates that the solution meets NFR benchmarks under expected and peak load conditions. Load testing tools (Apache JMeter, Gatling, or k6) simulate concurrent user volumes at 125% of projected peak. Regression testing ensures that defect fixes and late-stage configuration changes do not introduce unintended side effects. Automated regression suites are maintained throughout the Build and Test phases.

5.4 Test Phase Deliverables

- Test Strategy and Test Plan documents
- SIT execution results with defect metrics
- UAT execution results with business sign-off
- Performance test results against NFR benchmarks
- Regression test suite and execution logs
- Defect aging and resolution reports
- Test Phase Summary Report and Go-Live Readiness Assessment

Governance Checkpoint: Go-Live Readiness Gate. Steering Committee reviews test results, outstanding defect counts (zero critical, near-zero high), performance benchmarks, UAT sign-off status, and operational readiness. Formal Go/No-Go decision for production deployment.

6 Phase 5: Deploy (Weeks 32-40)

The Deploy phase transitions the solution from project delivery to business operations. This phase encompasses production cutover execution, hypercare support, knowledge transfer to the client's operational teams, and formal project closure. Meridian's deployment approach minimizes business disruption through detailed cutover planning and rehearsals.

6.1 Cutover Planning and Execution

The Cutover Plan is a minute-by-minute runbook that sequences all deployment activities, assigns responsibilities, defines rollback triggers and procedures, and establishes communication protocols. At least two cutover rehearsals are

conducted in a production-mirror environment before the actual go-live event. The cutover window is negotiated with the client to minimize impact on business operations, typically scheduled over a weekend or holiday period.

6.2 Hypercare and Stabilization

Meridian provides a dedicated hypercare team for 2-4 weeks post go-live. The hypercare team operates on an enhanced support model with 12-hour coverage (extendable to 24/7 for critical deployments), 15-minute response SLAs for severity-1 issues, and daily triage meetings with the client's operational leadership. Hypercare concludes with a formal Stabilization Assessment confirming that the solution is operating within defined tolerances.

6.3 Knowledge Transfer

Knowledge transfer begins during the Build phase and intensifies during Deploy. It includes formal training sessions for end users (role-based curricula), administrator training for IT operations, documentation handover (operations runbooks, configuration guides, architecture decision records), and shadowing periods where client staff work alongside Meridian consultants. Knowledge transfer effectiveness is measured through competency assessments and client readiness surveys.

6.4 Deploy Phase Deliverables

- Cutover Plan and Execution Checklist
- Production deployment verification report
- Hypercare daily status reports and issue logs
- Knowledge transfer completion certificates
- Operations runbooks and support documentation
- Project Closure Report with lessons learned
- Benefits Realization Baseline for post-project tracking

Governance Checkpoint: Project Closure Gate. Formal acceptance of all deliverables, confirmation that knowledge transfer is complete, transition to BAU support, financial close-out, and initiation of post-implementation review (scheduled 90 days after go-live).

7 Cross-Phase Governance Framework

Governance operates at three tiers throughout the project lifecycle. The Steering Committee (executive sponsors, C-suite representatives, Meridian Partner) meets monthly and at every phase gate to provide strategic direction and approve major decisions. The Project Board (project managers, workstream leads, business process owners) meets biweekly to manage scope, schedule, and budget. The Working Team (consultants, developers, testers, client SMEs) operates on a weekly cadence with daily standups during Build and Test phases.

All governance forums follow standardized agenda templates, action-item tracking protocols, and escalation procedures. Decision logs are maintained in the project's SharePoint site and linked to the relevant phase deliverables. RAID (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) logs are reviewed at every governance forum and updated in real time.

8 Related Case Studies & Key Personnel

The SPL has been successfully applied across engagements of all sizes and industries. The following case studies illustrate the SPL in practice across Meridian's client portfolio:

- Financial Services Digital Transformation (Sarah Chen, Lead Partner) -- Core banking modernization demonstrating full SPL lifecycle execution at enterprise scale.
- Healthcare EHR Integration (Michael Torres, Lead Partner) -- Multi-system integration following SPL with intensive OCM and regulatory compliance requirements.
- Manufacturing ERP Transformation (James O'Sullivan, Lead Partner) -- SAP S/4HANA implementation utilizing SPL with augmented Build and Data Migration phases.
- Public Sector Cloud Migration (Dr. Priya Ramanathan, Lead Partner) -- FedRAMP-compliant cloud migration following SPL governance with enhanced security gate reviews.
- Retail Omnichannel Analytics (Robert Adeyemi, Lead Partner) -- Data platform modernization leveraging SPL with iterative analytics delivery sprints.
- Energy Sector Operational Technology (Lead Partner) -- OT/IT convergence program applying SPL with specialized safety and environmental compliance checkpoints.

9 Related Meridian Methodologies

The Standard Project Lifecycle integrates with and is supported by the following Meridian practice-specific methodologies and frameworks. Engagement teams should reference these documents for domain-specific guidance within each SPL phase:

- Organizational Change Management Framework (v5.0) -- OCM activities are embedded in every SPL phase; the OCM Framework provides detailed guidance on stakeholder analysis, communications, training, and adoption measurement.
- Agile vs. Waterfall Delivery Methodology Guide (v3.0) -- Provides decision criteria and hybrid delivery models that operate within the SPL phase structure.
- Enterprise ERP Implementation Strategy (v2.3) -- SPL phases map directly to ERP implementation milestones; the ERP document provides platform-specific accelerators for SAP, Oracle, and Workday.
- Cloud Migration Methodology and Playbook (v3.5) -- Cloud migrations follow the SPL with augmented Discovery (Cloud Readiness Assessment) and Build (Migration Factory) activities.
- Cybersecurity Risk Assessment Methodology (v4.0) -- Security assessments are embedded in the SPL Design and Test phases; the Cybersecurity document provides the detailed assessment framework.
- Supply Chain Optimization Practice Guide (v2.1) -- Supply chain engagements follow the SPL with specialized analytical tools and industry benchmarks during Discovery and Design.
- Data, Analytics & AI Strategy Guide (v1.0) -- Data and AI engagements leverage the SPL with augmented current-state data maturity assessments and AI use case prioritization frameworks.